

SCHEDULE AND MESSAGES, ONE SYSTEM

THE SCHEDULE TALKS.

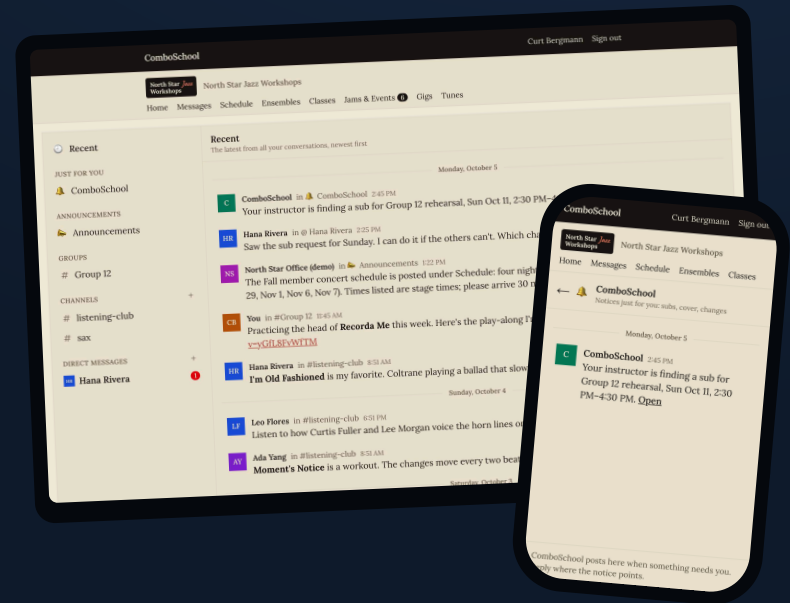
Every rehearsal, jam and concert comes with its conversation. When something on the schedule changes, the right people hear about it in their messages, and every message takes them straight back to the date.

Members post their own gigs, say **I'm going** to the jams, and find their section in **#sax** or **#bass**. And when it's time to practice, every tune your group plays opens to its changes in your own key, written out as real notation, with a rhythm section ready to play along.

And I built all of it in one day.

It's running now: northstar.jazzcombo.org

BY CURT BERGMANN • ALTO SAX, GROUP 12



HOW THIS HAPPENED

One member. *One day.* All of this.

I wrote the first line of ComboSchool at 10:20 on a Monday morning. By that evening it was running on the open internet at its own address, with North Star's schedule, groups, jams and tunes in it, a user manual for every role, and hundreds of automated tests checking it every time anything changed. Software that used to take a team months now takes a determined person a day. I still can't quite believe it, so here's the receipt.

1 day

FROM FIRST LINE TO A LIVE
WEBSITE

38

SCREENS

618

AUTOMATED TESTS, ALL PASSING

3

USER MANUALS, 15,000 WORDS

✓ Group conversations, set up from the roster

✓ Direct messages and small groups

✓ Topic channels and a channel for every section

- ✓ Office announcements, in the app and by email
- ✓ Sub requests the coach decides and the app asks
- ✓ A Gigs tab for everyone's own gigs
- ✓ A public calendar for the world
- ✓ Practice views as real notation
- ✓ Rehearsals, classes, lessons, jams and concerts
- ✓ Attendance and "can't make it"
- ✓ Recordings of rehearsals and concerts
- ✓ 666 standards and 3,337 chord charts
- ✓ A backing band in five styles, lighting the bar
- ✓ Drafts reviewed by faculty, then published
- ✓ RSVPs that land on your Home page
- ✓ Guardians included for minors
- ✓ Every key in your own instrument's key and clef
- ✓ Passkey sign-in, and a manual for every role

1

PLACE FOR THE SCHEDULE AND EVERY CONVERSATION

150

MEMBERS, COACHES AND GUARDIANS

1 tap

TO SAY YOU CAN'T MAKE IT

\$0

FOR NORTH STAR THROUGH 2026

THE BIG IDEA

YOUR CALENDAR AND YOUR GROUP CHAT, FINALLY TALKING.

Most schools run the schedule in one place and the conversation in another: a calendar, an email list, a group text. ComboSchool is **one system**, so the two stay in step on their own.

One app instead of two. North Star already uses My Music Staff (linked from its website) and the free version of Slack, which shows only the last 90 days of messages and deletes anything older than a year. ComboSchool could replace both: schedule, lessons, rosters and every conversation in one place, with history kept for good. Billing and payments are on the roadmap; until then, My Music Staff can keep handling those.

- **Every group has its conversation**, right beside its schedule. Group 12's chat and its Sunday rehearsals live together.
- **Changes reach exactly the right people.** A sub needed, a coach out, a jam published: the people involved hear it in Messages, and by email if they chose.
- **Every notice opens the date.** Tap **Open** and you're on the rehearsal, with the answer buttons right there.

SCHEDULE

Curt taps **Can't make it** for Sunday.

MESSAGES

Chris is asked to choose a sub. Alto players are asked to cover. Group 12 hears who's subbing.

BACK TO THE DATE

Each notice opens the rehearsal, where the sub says yes in one tap.

Cover

Note for the sub (optional)

Working on Monk tunes

1 can't make it, find cover

Subs

Curt Bergmann (Alto Saxophone) can't make it - asking people

Sam Chen (asked) Un-ask

Ada Yang (asked) Un-ask

Hana Rivera (asked) Un-ask

No sub Open to anyone

▼ Ask specific people...

☐ Ada Iverson Alto Saxophone - same instrument

☐ Ada Yang Alto Saxophone - same instrument

☐ Alex Mendez Alto Saxophone - same instrument

☐ Carlos Kowalski Alto Saxophone - same instrument

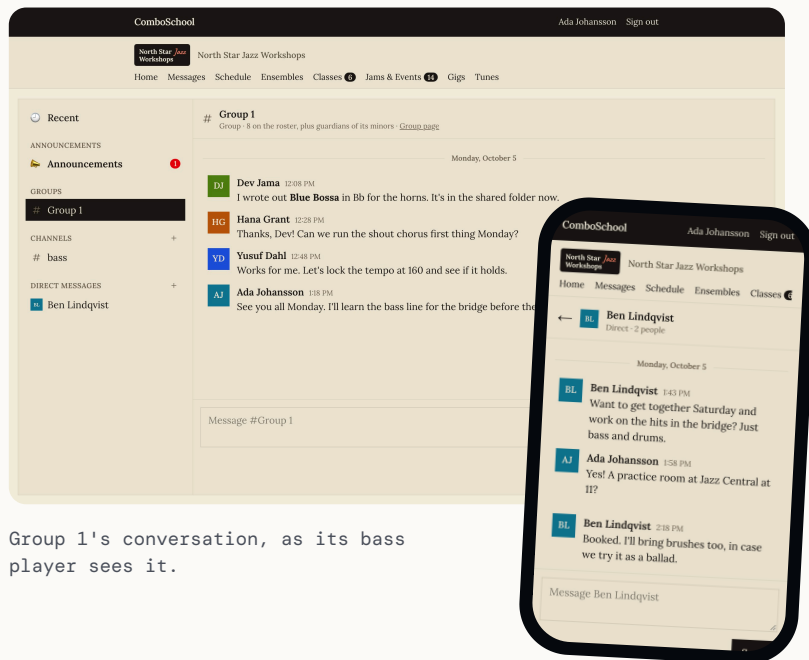
☐ Gloria Zimmerman Alto Saxophone - same instrument

☐ Hana Lindqvist Alto Saxophone - same instrument

Ask them

The rehearsal page Chris lands on from his notice.

- Recent shows it all together: the sub request, the reply about it, and the office's announcement, newest first.



Group 1's conversation, as its bass player sees it.

TALKING TO EACH OTHER

YOUR WHOLE GROUP, OR JUST ONE PERSON.

Every group gets its own conversation the day its roster is set: charts, tempos, who's bringing what. Nobody has to collect phone numbers or start a group text.

Members message each other directly, one to one or a few at a time, without trading personal numbers. A bass player and a drummer can book Saturday's practice room in three messages.

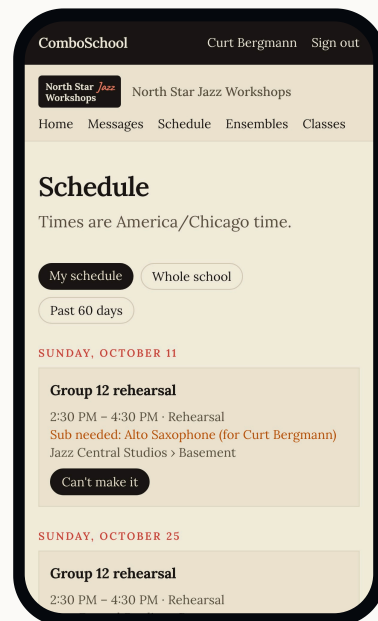
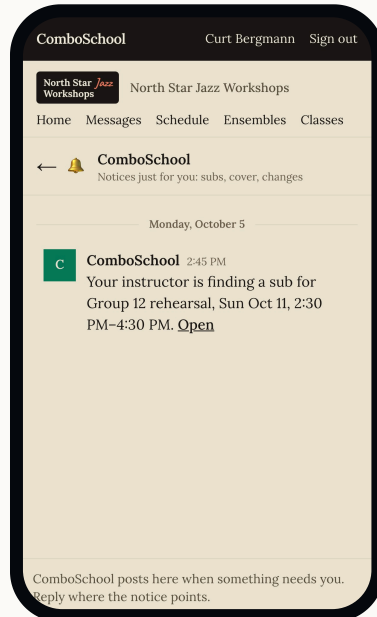
- A group's conversation includes exactly its current roster, plus guardians of any minors.
- A direct message that includes someone under 18 automatically includes their guardians.
- Unread counts, Recent, and email for the messages you choose.

FOR COACHES: SUBS

THE COACH DECIDES. THE APP DOES THE ASKING.

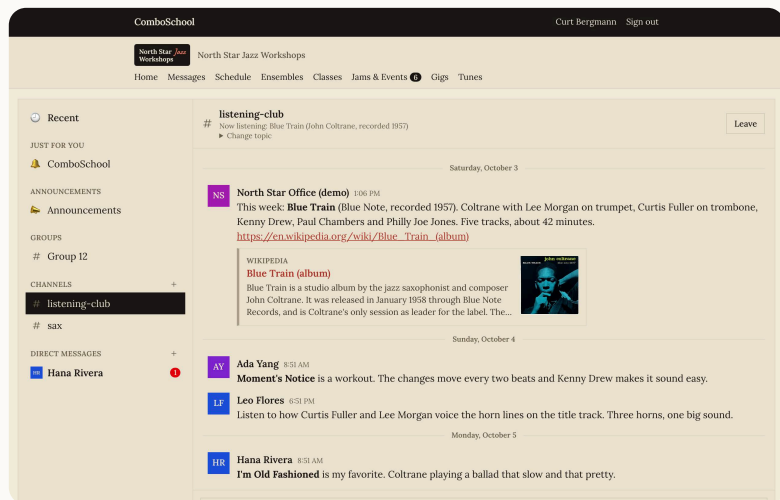
A player who can't make Sunday just says so. Chris gets a notice and picks what happens: **no sub**, **ask a few people** (players of the same instrument come up first), or **open it to anyone**.

ComboSchool sends the asks, the **first yes** gets the spot, and Chris, the player and the group are all told. If a sub backs out, the same people are asked again; if Chris asked the wrong person, **Un-ask** sends an apology. No phone tree.



NOBODY FINDS OUT AT THE DOOR ANYMORE.

Every step is a message to exactly the people involved, in the app and by email, the way each person chose.



#listening-club: one album a week, with its cover card and everyone's notes. Posts are from the office and fictional demo members.

CHANNELS

A LISTENING CLUB, RIGHT INSIDE.

Beyond the groups, anyone can join topic channels, the way Slack works. This week **#listening-club** is on *Blue Train*: Coltrane, Lee Morgan and Curtis Fuller, recorded in 1957.

- Browse every channel and join or leave with one tap.
- A topic line anyone in the channel can change: "Now listening: Blue Train".
- **Bold**, *italics* and links in any message. A link gets a preview card, like the album cover here.

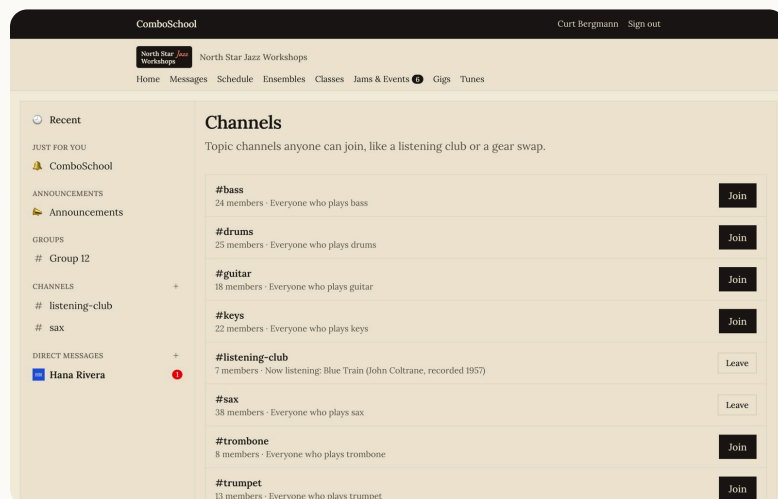
- Open channels for everyone, or private ones by invitation. Guardians come along with minors.

SECTION CHANNELS

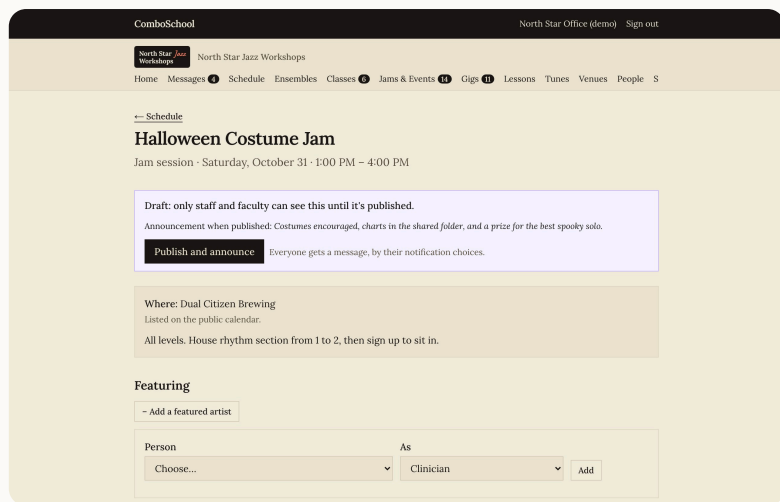
EVERY SECTION HAS ITS OWN ROOM.

#sax, #trumpet, #trombone, #bass, #keys, #guitar, #drums, #vibes, #vocals: ComboSchool makes a channel for every section from the instruments members play. Nobody has to set them up.

- **You're already in yours.** Alto, tenor and bari players all land in one #sax, and the channel follows your profile when you add an instrument.
- **Open to anyone.** A pianist curious about voicings can join #guitar, and leave with one tap.
- **Instruments are picked, never typed,** from a searchable list with a **Main** one first. So a sub request reaches the right players, and every part comes out in the right key.



Curt's channel list: he's in #sax because he plays alto. Member counts are the demo school's.

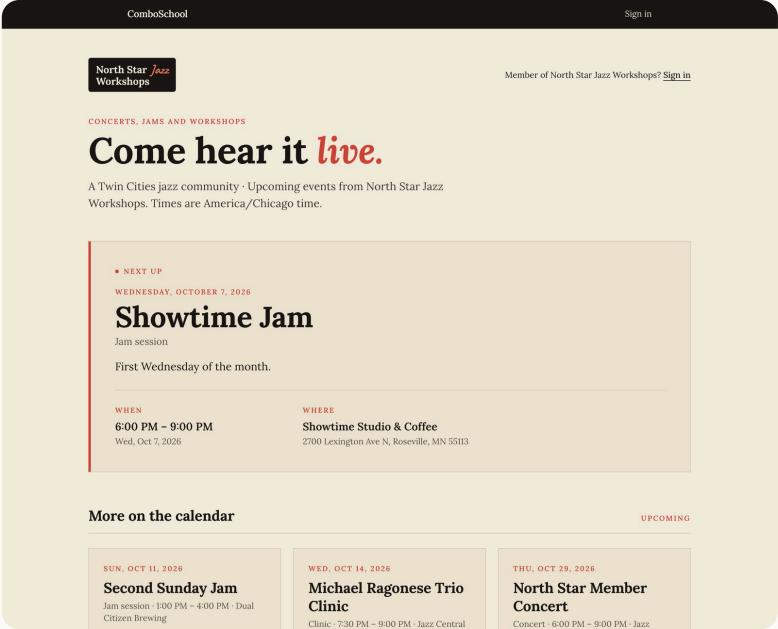


JAMS & EVENTS

DRAFTED, REVIEWED, THEN ANNOUNCED.

A new jam, clinic, show or concert night starts as a **draft** that only staff and faculty can see. Faculty mark **Looks good** or leave a note.

When it's ready, the office taps **Publish and announce**, and everyone gets the message with its own announcement text.



The public calendar at /p/northstar: what anyone sees, no sign-in.

GIGS

WHERE EVERYONE'S PLAYING THIS WEEK.

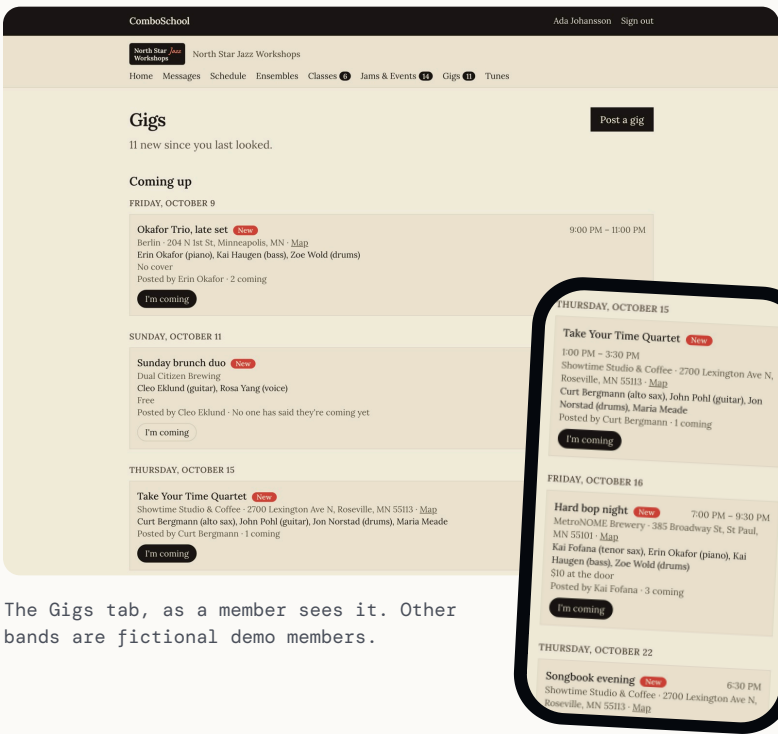
Members play all over town, and until now you heard about it by word of mouth. The **Gigs** tab is where they tell each other. Anyone taps **Post a gig** at the top: the day, the room, the lineup, the cover.

Mine is on there: the **Take Your Time Quartet**, third Thursdays, 1 to 3:30, at Showtime Studio & Coffee, with John Pohl, Jon Norstad and Maria Meade.

- Everyone sees it, with a **New** badge, and posting it announces it to the whole school in Announcements, with an **Open** link.
- **I'm coming** puts it on your Home page and your schedule, and tells the band how many to expect.
- The poster edits or deletes it; the office can remove any gig.

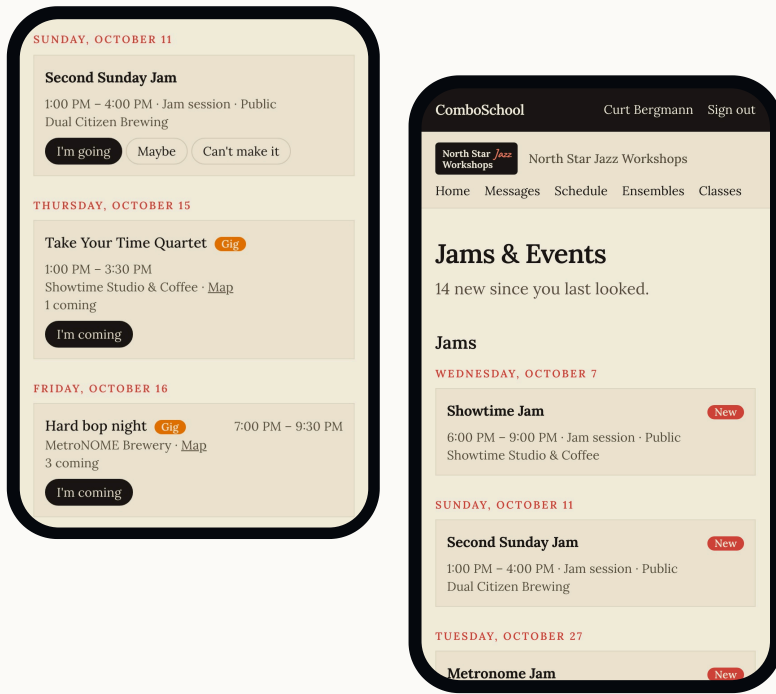
Members see a **New** badge until they've seen it.

Anything marked public also goes up on North Star's **public calendar**, open to anyone with no sign-in and laid out like the events page on northstarjazzworkshops.com: the next date up top, then the rest of the season.



The Gigs tab, as a member sees it. Other bands are fictional demo members.

SAY YOU'RE GOING. IT'S ON YOUR HOME.



The Second Sunday Jam at Dual Citizen Brewing, the Metronome Jam on the last Tuesday at MetroNOME Brewery, the Showtime Jam on the first Wednesday: North Star's jams, member concerts, clinics and faculty nights sit together under **Jams & Events**, and anything you haven't seen is marked **New**.

Answer **I'm going**, **Maybe** or **Can't make it** to a jam, clinic or show, **I'm coming** to a concert, and it joins **Coming up** on your Home page beside your rehearsals and the gigs you're going to. Guardians see their kids' too.

- Rehearsals set once as a series: 2nd and 4th Sundays, 2:30 to 4:30, Jazz Central basement.
- Double-booked rooms are flagged for the office.
- Phone apps for iPhone and Android come from the same code.

COACH COVER

OUT SICK? ONE BUTTON TELLS THE FACULTY.

A coach taps **I can't make it, find cover**. Faculty see it at once, a colleague takes it or the office assigns one, and the group hears who's leading. The sub can take attendance for that one rehearsal and nothing more.

BETWEEN REHEARSALS

THEN GO HOME AND PRACTICE.

The schedule gets everyone into the room. The tune pages make the room sound better: every tune your group plays, with its chord changes in your own key, practice exercises written out as music, and a bass player and compere who never get tired of the bridge.

3,337

CHORD CHARTS TO DRAW ON

666

43

5

TUNES: THE CHANGES

EVERY CHART, IN YOUR KEY.

Open a tune and its **chord changes** are right there: a clean grid, four bars to a row, with section letters, real repeat signs, first and second endings, codas, segnos and the final barline. Written for **your** instrument, not just "E ♭ or B ♭ ": alto and tenor, trumpet, clarinet, trombone in bass clef, guitar an octave up, voice. 43 instruments in all, and **Keys for** switches to anyone else's.

The changes come from a **3,337-chart chord reference** (iReal Pro playlists, the iReal forum and the Real Book). The library starts with **666 standards**; search for anything else, and a tune with changes joins your practice list or your group's book with one click.

Chord changes and practice

▶ Play

Tempo 120 bpm

Style

From the chart (Swing) ▾

☒ Count-in

☒ Loop

For Alto Saxophone · Medium Swing · 4/4

Bass

Chords

Click

Chords

Roots

Arpeggios

Scales

Leading tones

Analysis

A	Am7	D7	Gmaj7	Cmaj7
	F#ø7	B7b13	Em6	Em6 :
B	F#ø7	B7b13	Em6	Em6
	Am7	D7	Gmaj7	Cmaj7
C	F#ø7	B7b13	Em7 D#7	Dm7 C#7
	F#ø7	B7b13	Em6	Em6

Chords from [ChoCo \(Chord Corpus\)](#) (CC BY 4.0), iReal Pro charts. Practice views and the backing track follow SetCraft's (JazzCore's) exercises, harmonic analysis and accompaniment. Playback sounds at concert pitch.

Autumn Leaves as Curt reads it on alto: concert Gm, written Em, every chord already transposed.

ROOTS Each chord's root, held as long as the chord lasts. Hear the bass line, learn the form.

SCALES

The scale for each chord, stepping through the changes, with the altered notes in view.

ANALYSIS A lead sheet of the harmony. **Simplified** names the scale in force; **Advanced** adds Roman numerals, ii-V-I brackets and secondary dominants.

It's the same analysis and the same exercises as my own improv practice app, held to that app's output character for character by automated tests.

The screenshot displays the "Chord changes and practice" application interface. At the top, there's a title bar with controls for Play, Tempo (set to 120 bpm), Style (set to "From the chart (Swing)"), Count-in, and Loop. Below this, it specifies the instrument as "For Alto Saxophone · Medium Swing · 4/4". The main section shows three staves of music with chord progressions. The first staff has chords Am7, D7, Gmaj7, and Cmaj7. The second staff has ii, V, I, and b VI E minor, with F#m7 b5 and B7 b13 indicated below. The third staff has iio, ii-V-i (minor) in E minor, and Em6, also with F#m7 b5 and B7 b13 indicated. A bottom section shows the same progression in F minor: iio, V7, i, and ii-V-i (minor) in F minor. On the right side, there's a smaller version of the app interface, labeled "Chord changes and practice", which includes the same controls and a list of written keys: Em, From the 3rd, and From the 7th.

A RHYTHM SECTION ON CALL.

Press **Play** and a band comes in: **sampled bass, Rhodes comping** and a woodblock click. The groove comes from the chart, or pick one: **Swing, Latin, Ballad, Waltz, Jazz Manouche**.

Jazz Manouche brings in a guitar playing **la pompe** the way Django's rhythm players did, *ka-BOOM, CHAK*, and it keeps pumping through bars with two chords.

- **Your tempo**, a bar of count-in, and a loop that goes round as long as you do.
- **Your mix**: Bass, Chords and Click each have a volume, and in a practice view the **Line** plays the exercise over the band.
- **Never lose your place**. The bar being played lights up in the grid, in the notation and on the Analysis lead sheet, through repeats and endings as written.
- **Stop is always in reach**, pinned to the bottom of the screen however far you scroll.

Chord changes and practice

■ Stop

Tempo

120 bpm

Style

From the chart (Latin) ▼

☑ Count-in

☑ Loop

For Alto Saxophone · Bossa Nova · 4/4

Bass

Chords

Click

Line

Chords

Roots

Arpeggios

Scales

Leading tones

Analysis

Written key: Am

Chord roots: Blue Bossa

Am7

Dm7

Bm7 ♭ 5

E7 ♭ 9

Am7

Cm7

F7

B ♭ maj7

Bm7 ♭ 5

E7 ♭ 9

Am7

Bm7 ♭ 5

E7 ♭ 9

Chords from ChoCo (Chord Corpus) (CC BY 4.0), Real Pro charts.

■ Stop playing

Backing track follow SetCraft's (JazzCore's) exercises, harmonic

Blue Bossa, Roots view, mid-chorus: the lit bar follows the band, and Stop stays pinned.

FOR THE WHOLE GROUP

EVERYONE ON THE SAME PAGE, IN THEIR OWN KEY.

A group's **repertoire** lists its book, and under each tune a **Parts** line gives every player's key from the instrument they play in that group. Nobody shows up to rehearsal having learned it in the wrong key.

- **Players build the book**. Anyone in an ensemble can add tunes to its repertoire; classes, jams and events stay with their instructors.
- **And Sunday's list**. Players add tunes to their group's upcoming rehearsals and can take off the ones they added; once the rehearsal is over, only the instructor changes it.

Repertoire (23)

+ Add a tune

Keys for

Alto Saxophone ▼

All Of Me in E (G concert) · Swing
Parts: John (Guitar): G treble 8vb · Curt (Alto Saxophone): E

Autumn Leaves in F#m (Am concert) · Swing
Parts: John (Guitar): Am treble 8vb · Curt (Alto Saxophone): F#m

Black Orpheus in Dm (Fm concert) · Bossa
Parts: John (Guitar): Fm treble 8vb · Curt (Alto Saxophone): Dm

Caravan in Em (Gm concert) · Latin/Swing
Parts: John (Guitar): Gm treble 8vb · Curt (Alto Saxophone): Em

Four on Six in Em (Gm concert)
Parts: John (Guitar): Gm treble 8vb · Curt (Alto Saxophone): Em

If I Should Lose You in Am (Cm concert)
Parts: John (Guitar): Cm treble 8vb · Curt (Alto Saxophone): Am

In the Wee Small Hours of the Morning in F (A ♭ concert)
Parts: John (Guitar): A ♭ treble 8vb · Curt (Alto Saxophone): F

It's a Big Wide Wonderful World in D (F concert)
Parts: John (Guitar): F treble 8vb · Curt (Alto Saxophone): D

Group 12's book: every tune with each player's part key, guitar (an octave up) and alto alike.

- **My practice list**, private to each player (and a guardian for minors), sits at the top of Tunes.
- **Concert nights carry each group's set**, so the program and the practice pages are the same tunes.

SAFE BY DESIGN

- Members under 13 have no login; guardians act for them.
- Messages to a minor include their guardians.
- Lessons are private to teacher, student and guardians.
- Sign in with an emailed link or a passkey (Face ID or Touch ID), no passwords. The sign-in page remembers your email; untick it on a public computer.
- The rules are enforced in the database itself.

WHAT IT COSTS

MONTHLY		
Database, sign-in, file storage		\$25
Website hosting		\$20
Email (up to 3,000 a month)		Free
YEARLY		
Apple App Store membership		\$99
Web address (domain)	about	\$15
ONE TIME		
Google Play registration		\$25
Through December 2026		Free
Each year from 2027	about	\$655

2026 is on me. I'm learning too, so North Star pays nothing through the end of December. From 2027 it's at cost, nothing more: these are the services' own charges, passed straight through. I'm not making any money from ComboSchool.

Approximate list prices, not quotes. No per-member fees and no text-message charges.

WHERE IT STANDS

- **Live:** running now at northstar.jazzcombo.org, on demo data: Group 12's Sundays are real, the other members made up. The public calendar at [/p/northstar](https://p/northstar) is open to anyone.
- **Built:** people, groups, schedule, subs, cover, messages, section channels, drafts and publishing, members' gigs, RSVPs on Home; tunes with chord changes in every player's key, practice notation, backing tracks, group repertoires and concert sets.
- **In progress:** photos and files in messages, reactions, class sign-ups.
- **Next:** invoices and payments with Stripe, then the phone apps.

COMPARED WITH TODAY

WHAT CHANGES, SIDE BY SIDE.

TODAY: MY MUSIC STAFF + FREE SLACK		COMBOSCHOOL
Cost through 2026	My Music Staff: \$16.95/mo with one login, about \$76/mo if all 13 teachers log in. Slack: free.	Free
Cost from 2027	The same	About \$55/mo, flat, however many log in
Message history	Last 90 days visible; older than a year deleted	Kept for good

Conversations tied to rosters and the schedule	No: Slack doesn't know the groups or the dates	Yes: every group's chat, every notice opens its date
Subs, coach cover, recordings	Phone, email and text	Built in
Members' gigs and jam RSVPs	A Slack post, if someone sees it in time	A Gigs tab, I'm going on every jam, all on your Home page
Practice tools for players	None: Slack and My Music Staff don't know the tunes	Every tune's changes in each player's key, practice views as notation, a backing track
Invoices, online payments, autopay	Yes (My Music Staff)	Coming next, with Stripe
Card fees	Stripe or PayPal rates	Stripe rates, no cut

My Music Staff: \$16.95/month for the first user plus \$4.95 per additional teacher or staff login (mymusicstaff.com/pricing). Slack free-plan limits from Slack's help center. Prices as of October 2026.

COMING NEXT • NOT BUILT YET

INVOICES AND PAYMENTS, WITH STRIPE.

The last thing My Music Staff does that ComboSchool doesn't: monthly invoices and paying online. The plan is to add it with **Stripe**, the standard for apps like this.

- **The money goes straight to North Star.** The school connects its own Stripe account. ComboSchool never holds funds and takes no cut.
- **Monthly invoices** built from rosters and lessons, with a **Pay online** button and automatic "Paid" once the payment clears.
- **Autopay.** A member or guardian saves a card or bank account once on Stripe's secure page and ticks *Pay automatically each month*. Reminder before each charge, emailed receipt after, automatic retries if a card fails.
- **Members stay in control:** switch autopay off, change the card, or pay any invoice by hand.
- **The office sees it all:** who's on autopay, what's paid, what's overdue.

STRIPE'S FEES

PER PAYMENT, PAID BY THE SCHOOL

Card (and Apple Pay, Google Pay)	2.9% + 30¢
Bank account (ACH)	0.8%, max \$5

ON A \$150 MONTHLY INVOICE

By card	about \$4.65
By bank account	about \$1.20

EVERYTHING ELSE

Monthly fee, autopay, receipts	None
ComboSchool's cut	None

Approximate list prices; check stripe.com/pricing. Autopay by bank account is the cheapest way to pay.

I WENT A LITTLE CRAZY TODAY.

I retired from a career in technology, and for a while now I've been building two apps for myself: one to run my gigs, and one to practice jazz improvisation. Today I went a little crazy and built this for North Star: a website that works on any phone, with iPhone and Android apps next, all in a day.

I mean that literally. Everything in this brochure, every screen you see, the messaging, the schedule, the gigs, the channels, the tune library and the practice tools, went from nothing to running live between a Monday morning and that evening, with 618 automated tests and three user manuals to show for it. Along the way I fixed things in my own two apps, because they share the same music engine. Five years ago this would have been a team and a budget. Today it was me, a laptop, and a very long cup of coffee.

Honestly, it helps me too. As a Group 12 player I wanted one place for our schedule, our conversation and our tunes. The tune library, the chord charts and the practice views come straight from my own apps, so the tools that help me learn a tune are here for everyone.

That's the part I'm proudest of. The harmonic analysis, the exercises and the backing band are the same ones I practice with every day, checked against my app note for note. If a student at North Star wants to know why the bridge of Autumn Leaves feels the way it does, it's one tap away, in their key.

CURT BERGMANN · ALTO SAX, GROUP 12

THE ASK

ONE TERM. THREE OR FOUR GROUPS. FREE.

- 1 Pick the pilot groups and willing coaches. Group 12 is already set up.
- 2 The office invites those members on the live site. Each signs in from an emailed link, then saves a passkey if they like.
- 3 Coaches run subs, cover and group messages through it; the office posts those groups' jams and concerts; players RSVP, post their gigs and learn the book from the tune pages, in their own keys.
- 4 At term's end, compare time spent on subs and cover, and ask members whether they'd keep it, and whether they practiced more.

QUESTIONS FOR THE FACULTY

- Which groups should pilot, and which coaches are in?
- Should subs default to "ask people" or "open to anyone"?
- Who publishes events, and do drafts need faculty sign-off?
- Is email enough for last-minute changes until the phone apps arrive?
- Would coaches point players to the practice views between rehearsals, or use them in the room?
- What would make you stop using it?

ComboSchool · built by a North Star member: free through 2026, at cost after, never for profit

Live at northstar.jazzcombo.org. Screens show the app running on demo data. Group 12's schedule and venue, North Star's jams and Curt's quartet are real; other members are fictional.